

Introduction to Linguistics (ENG502)

- ✚ **WHAT IS LANGUAGE?:** Language is a system of communication that consists of a set of rules and symbols used to convey meaning and express thoughts, ideas, and experiences. It is a fundamental aspect of human society, enabling us to interact, share knowledge, and build relationships.
- ✚ **Language:** A Purely Human and Non-Instinctive: Language is a unique and exclusive attribute of humans, distinguishing us from animals. It is a learned skill, not an innate ability, and is shaped by culture, history, and social context. Human language is complex, creative, and symbolic, setting it apart from other forms of communication.
- ✚ **Communication:** Language is a unique characteristic of humans, unlike animal communication, which is largely instinctive. Human language is learned, not innate, and is shaped by culture, environment, and social context.
- ✚ **Language: A Symbol System:** Language uses symbols, such as words, sounds, and gestures, to represent concepts, objects, and ideas. These symbols are arbitrary, meaning their meaning is not inherent but agreed upon by the language community.
- ✚ **Behavioristic View of Language:** The behavioristic view sees language as a behavior shaped by environment, conditioning, and reinforcement. It emphasizes the role of imitation, habit, and association in language learning and use.
- ✚ **Structural View of Language:** The structural view, developed by linguist Ferdinand de Saussure, sees language as a system of signs with underlying rules and structures. It analyzes language as a network of relationships between signs and their meanings.
- ✚ **Miscellaneous Definitions of Language:** Language has been defined in various ways, such as a tool for communication, a means of expression, a system of signs, a social construct, and a reflection of culture and thought.
- ✚ **HISTORY OF LANGUAGE:** The history of language is long and complex, spanning millions of years. It is believed to have originated from gestures, sounds, and facial expressions, evolving into complex systems of communication.
- ✚ **Animal Communication and Language:** Animals communicate using various signals, such as sounds, gestures, and body language. While they do not possess language in the human sense, their communication systems share some similarities with human language.

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- ✚ **Talking Apes:** Some primates, like chimpanzees and gorillas, have been taught human sign language, demonstrating an ability to learn and use language symbols.
- ✚ **Written Language:** Written language developed around 5,000 years ago, allowing for the recording and transmission of language across time and space.
- ✚ **First Families:** The first language families, such as Indo-European and Sino-Tibetan, emerged around 6,000-8,000 years ago, spreading across continents and giving rise to many modern languages.
- ✚ **Towards a Science of Language:** The study of language has evolved into a scientific discipline, incorporating insights from linguistics, psychology, anthropology, and computer science to understand the nature, structure, and use of language.
- ✚ **Future Indicatives:** The future of language is shaped by technological advancements, globalization, and evolving human communication needs, likely leading to new forms of language, such as digital and virtual communication systems.
- ✚ **The Divine Source:** language as a gift from God or gods
- ✚ **The Natural Sound Source:** language emerging from natural sounds and gestures
- ✚ **The Social Interaction Source:** language developing through social interaction and communication needs
- ✚ **The Physical Adaptation Source:**

Language may have originated from physical adaptations such as:

- ✓ Gestures and body language
- ✓ Facial expressions and emotions
- ✓ Vocalizations and sound-making abilities

✚ **The Tool-Making Source**

Language may have emerged as a result of tool-making and:

- ✓ Cognitive abilities to create and use tools
- ✓ Need for communication to coordinate tool-making activities
- ✓ Development of symbolic thinking and representation

✚ **The Genetic Source:**

- ✓ Inherent abilities for language acquisition and use
- ✓ Evolutionary advantages for language development
- ✓ Genetic predispositions for language structure and organization

✚ **Characteristics of Human Language**

- ✓ Displacement
- ✓ Arbitrariness
- ✓ Productivity
- ✓ Cultural Transmission
- ✓ Duality

- ✚ **Displacement:** language allows us to communicate about things not present

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- ✚ **Arbitrariness:** language symbols have no inherent meaning
- ✚ **Productivity:** language enables us to create new expressions and meanings
- ✚ **Cultural Transmission:** language is passed down through culture and society
- ✚ **Duality:** language has both a tangible (sound, writing) and intangible (meaning, thought) aspect

✚ **Functions of Language**

- ✓ **Language is Expressive:** Language allows us to express thoughts, feelings, and ideas (e.g., "I'm so happy to see you!").
- ✓ **Language is Powerful:** Language can influence others, shape opinions, and assert control (e.g., political speeches).
- ✓ **Language is Performative:** Language can perform actions, make promises, and create commitments (e.g., "I promise to meet you at 5 pm").

✚ **NONVERBAL COMMUNICATION AND LINGUISTICS**

- ✓ **Aspects of Nonverbal Communication:** (Facial expressions, body language, tone of voice, and eye contact convey meaning beyond spoken language.)
- ✓ **Principles of Nonverbal Communication:** Nonverbal cues can reinforce, contradict, or complement verbal messages (e.g., a smile can reinforce a friendly verbal message).
- ✓ **Conveyance of Interpersonal and Emotional Messages:** Nonverbal communication conveys emotions, attitudes, and relationships (e.g., a hug can convey empathy and support).

✚ **Types of Nonverbal Communication Learning**

- ✓ **Kinesics** (body language): Understanding and using body language effectively, such as maintaining eye contact during a conversation
- ✓ **Haptics** (touch): Using touch to communicate comfort, support, or affection (e.g., holding hands with a friend).
- ✓ **Vocalics** (tone of voice),
- ✓ **Proxemics** (personal space), and
- ✓ **Chronemics** (time and punctuality)

- ✚ **Animal vs. Human Communication:** Animal communication is largely instinctive and limited, while human communication is complex, creative, and open-ended (e.g., humans can create new words and sentences). Human language has a unique ability to convey abstract thoughts and ideas, unlike animal communication.

- ✚ **Broadcast Transmission and Directional Reception:** Human language allows for broadcast transmission (speaking to multiple people at once) and directional reception (addressing a specific person or group). Example: A teacher speaking to a classroom of students, using language to direct attention and convey information.

- ✚ **Creativity/Novelty/ Prevarication:** Human language enables creativity (generating new ideas and expressions), novelty (producing new sentences and meanings), and

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prevarication (telling lies or misrepresenting truth). Example: A poet creating a new metaphor or a politician spinning a story to persuade voters.

✚ **Discreteness:** Human language is composed of discrete units (words, sounds, gestures) that can be combined and recombined to create new meanings. Example: The words "happy" and "birthday" can be combined to create a new phrase "Happy Birthday".

✚ **Interchangeability:** Human language allows for interchangeability, where words and sounds can be substituted or replaced to convey different meanings. Example: Using "run" instead of "sprint" to convey a similar idea.

✚ **Semanticity:** Human language has semanticity, meaning that words and symbols have meaning and can be used to convey complex ideas and concepts. Example: The word "love" conveying a complex emotional concept.

✚ **WHAT IS LINGUISTICS?:** Linguistics is the scientific study of language, exploring its structure, properties, and usage. Linguistics aims to understand how language works, how it is used, and how it varies across cultures and societies.

✚ **Explicitness:** Linguistics seeks to make language explicit, analyzing and describing its underlying rules and patterns. Example: Identifying the grammatical rules that govern sentence structure.

✚ **Systematicness:** Linguistics approaches language as a systematic and organized system, examining how its components fit together. Example: Analyzing how sounds, words, and sentences combine to convey meaning.

✚ **Objectivity:** Linguistics strives for objectivity, aiming to describe language without bias or personal opinion. Example: Describing the grammatical features of a language without judging its aesthetic value.

✚ **The Scope of Linguistic:** Linguistics encompasses various subfields, including phonetics, phonology, morphology, syntax, semantics, and pragmatics. Example: Studying the sound system of a language (phonetics) or how words are formed (morphology).

✚ Intra-disciplinary Branches of Linguistics

- ✓ **General-Linguistics:** Studies the fundamental nature of language, its properties, and universal characteristics (e.g., exploring how language conveys meaning).
- ✓ **Descriptive-Linguistics:** Analyzes the structure and organization of specific languages, describing their sound systems, grammar, and vocabulary (e.g., describing the grammar rules of English).
- ✓ **Comparative Linguistics:** Compares and contrasts different languages to identify similarities and differences (e.g., comparing the sound systems of English and Spanish).
- ✓ **Historical-Linguistics:** Examines the evolution and change of languages over time, tracing their development and relationships (e.g., studying how Latin influenced the development of French).

✚ Inter-disciplinary Branches

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- ✓ **Sociolinguistics**: Explores the relationship between language and society, examining how language varies with social factors like culture, class, and gender (e.g., studying how language use differs across different social classes).
 - ✓ **Psycholinguistics**: Investigates how language is processed in the mind, exploring language acquisition, perception, and production (e.g., studying how children learn language).
 - ✓ **Applied Linguistics**: Applies linguistic theories and methods to practical problems, such as language teaching, language planning, and speech therapy (e.g., developing language teaching materials).
 - ✓ **Computational Linguistics**: Develops computational models and algorithms to analyze, process, and generate human language (e.g., building machine translation systems).
 - ✓ **Geographical Linguistics**: Examines the geographical distribution of languages and dialects, studying how language varies across regions and spaces (e.g., mapping the dialects of English in the United States).
- ✚ **Linguistics**: Scientific Study of Language: Linguistics is the systematic and objective study of language, exploring its structure, properties, and usage. Example: Analyzing the sound system of English to understand how sounds are produced and used.
- ✚ **Linguistics and Descriptivism**: Linguistics aims to describe language as it is used, without judgment or prescription. Example: Describing the grammar and vocabulary of African American Vernacular English (AAVE) without evaluating its validity.
- ✚ **Linguistics**: Non-Speculative Nature: Linguistics relies on empirical evidence and observation, avoiding speculative or intuitive claims. Example: Studying the acoustic properties of speech sounds using instruments and experiments.
- ✚ **Linguistics and Objectivity**: Linguistics strives for objectivity, aiming to describe language without personal bias or cultural prejudice. Example: Analyzing the phonological system of a language without evaluating its aesthetic value.
- ✚ **Linguistics and Spoken Language**: Linguistics focuses on spoken language as the primary data, recognizing its central role in human communication. Example: Studying the intonation patterns of spoken English to understand its role in conveying meaning.

✚ PHONETICS AND ITS BRANCHES

Phonetics is the study of the physical properties of speech sounds

- ✓ **Articulatory Phonetics**: studies how sounds are produced by the vocal organs (e.g., how the tongue positions for different sounds)
- ✓ **Acoustic Phonetics**: examines the physical properties of sound waves (e.g., frequency, amplitude).
- ✓ **Auditory Phonetics**: investigates how listeners perceive and process speech sounds.
- ✓ **Instrumental Phonetics**: uses instruments to measure and analyze speech sounds (e.g., spectrograms)

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- ✚ **PHONOLOGY:** Phonology is the study of sound systems and patterns
- ✚ **Difference Between Phonetics and Phonology:** Phonetics studies the physical properties of speech sounds, while phonology examines sound systems and patterns.
- ✚ **Phoneme:** The Basic Unit of Phonology: A phoneme is a distinct sound unit in a language, distinguished by its acoustic properties and distribution. Example: The /p/ and /b/ sounds in English are distinct phonemes.
- ✚ **Segmental Phonology:** focuses on individual sounds (phonemes) and their distribution.
- ✚ **Supra-segmental Phonology:** examines sound patterns beyond individual segments (e.g., intonation, rhythm).
- ✚ **SYLLABLE:** A syllable is a unit of sound organization in a word, containing a vowel sound and optionally surrounding consonants. Example: The word "cat" has one syllable, while "banana" has three syllables (ba-na-na).
- ✚ **Syllable and Division of Words into Syllables:** Words can be divided into syllables using rules like dividing between vowels or between a vowel and a consonant. Example: Dividing the word "information" into syllables: in-for-ma-tion (4 syllables).
- ✚ **The Structure of the Syllable:** A syllable typically consists of an onset (initial consonant(s)), a nucleus (vowel sound), and a coda (final consonant(s)). Example: The syllable "cat" has an onset "c", nucleus "a", and coda "t".
- ✚ **Syllabic Consonants:** Some consonants can function as syllable nuclei, like the "l" in "bottle" or the "m" in "rhythm". Example: The "l" in "bottle" is a syllabic consonant, forming a syllable on its own.
- ✚ **Types of the Syllable:** Syllables can be classified as open (ending in a vowel) or closed (ending in a consonant). Example: The syllable "go" is open, while "got" is closed.
- ✚ **Consonant Clusters:** Consonant clusters occur when two or more consonants appear together, like "th" or "str". Example: The word "strength" starts with a consonant cluster "str".
- ✚ **Abutting Consonants:** Abutting consonants occur when two consonants appear together without a vowel, like "black" or "tenth". Example: The word "tenth" has abutting consonants "n" and "th".
- ✚ **STRESS:** Stress refers to the emphasis placed on a syllable or word in speech. Example: In the word "banana", the stress falls on the second syllable (ba-NAna).
- ✚ **Word-stress:** Stress can fall on different syllables in a word, like "PHO-tog-raphy" or "pho-TOG-raphy". Example: The word "photography" has stress on the second syllable (pho-TOG-raphy).
- ✚ **Sentence Stress:** Stress can also fall on specific words or syllables in a sentence to convey meaning or emphasis. Example: "I didn't say you stole my money" (emphasis on "you").
- ✚ **Syllable-timed Languages and Stress-timed Languages:** Languages can be classified as syllable-timed (each syllable takes equal time) or stress-timed (stressed syllables take more time). Example: English is a stress-timed language, while French is syllable-timed.

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- ✚ **General Rules of Stress:** Stress patterns can vary across languages, but often follow rules like stressing the penultimate syllable in a word. Example: In English, the word "information" stresses the penultimate syllable (in-for-MA-tion).
- ✚ **Morphology:** Morphology is the study of the structure and formation of words, examining how morphemes (smallest units of language) combine to form words. Example: The word "unhappiness" consists of three morphemes: "un-" (prefix), "happi-" (root), and "-ness" (suffix).
- ✚ **Morpheme:** A morpheme is the smallest unit of language, carrying meaning or function, and can be a root, prefix, suffix, or infix. Example: The morpheme "-ed" is a suffix indicating past tense in verbs (e.g., "walked").
- ✚ **Free Morphemes:** Free morphemes are words that can stand alone, like "cat" or "run". Example: The word "cat" is a free morpheme, as it has meaning on its own.
- ✚ **Bound Morphemes:** Bound morphemes are morphemes that must combine with other morphemes to carry meaning, like prefixes or suffixes. Example: The morpheme "-un-" (meaning "not") is a bound morpheme, as it must attach to a root word (e.g., "unhappy").
- ✚ **Lexical Morphemes:** Lexical morphemes carry meaning and function as words or parts of words, like roots or free morphemes. Example: The root morpheme "happi-" carries meaning related to happiness.
- ✚ **Functional Morphemes:** Functional morphemes serve a grammatical function, like indicating tense or case, and often have no meaning on their own. Example: The morpheme "-ed" is a functional morpheme, indicating past tense in verbs.
- ✚ **Derivational Morphemes:** Derivational morphemes change the meaning or function of a word, like adding a prefix or suffix to create a new word. Example: Adding the suffix "-ness" to "happi-" creates the new word "happiness".
- ✚ **Inflectional Morphemes:** Inflectional morphemes indicate grammatical information like tense, case, or number, without changing the word's core meaning. Example: The morpheme "-s" indicates plural number in nouns (e.g., "cats").
- ✚ **Derivational vs. Inflectional Morphemes:** Derivational morphemes create new words, while inflectional morphemes modify existing words to indicate grammatical information.
- ✚ **Morphological Description:** Morphological description analyzes how morphemes combine to form words and identifies patterns and rules. Example: Describing how the morphemes "un-", "happi-", and "-ness" combine to form "unhappiness".
- ✚ **Problems in Morphological Description:** Morphological description can be challenging due to irregularities, exceptions, and complexities in language. Example: The English language has many irregular verb forms, making morphological description tricky.
- ✚ **Morphs and Allomorphs:** Morphs are actual forms of morphemes, while allomorphs are variant forms of morphemes that occur in specific contexts. Example: The morpheme "-ed" has allomorphs like "-d" or "-t" in different verb forms (e.g., "walked", "liked").

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- ✚ **Coinage:** Coinage refers to the creation of new words or morphemes, often through derivation or compounding. Example: The word "selfie" is a recent coinage, formed by combining "self" and the suffix "-ie".
- ✚ **Borrowing:** Borrowing occurs when a language adopts words or morphemes from another language. Example: English borrowed the word "sushi" from Japanese.
- ✚ **Compounding / Blending:** Compounding combines two or more words to create a new word, while blending combines parts of words. Example: The word "smog" is a blend of "smoke" and "fog".
- ✚ **Clipping:** Clipping shortens a word or phrase to create a new form, like "phone" from "telephone". Example: The word "phone" is a clipping of "telephone".
- ✚ **Acronyms:** Acronyms form new words from the initial letters of a phrase, like "NASA" from "National Aeronautics and Space Administration". Example: The word "NASA" is an acronym.
- ✚ **Derivation (Prefixes, Suffixes, Infixes):** Derivation involves adding affixes (prefixes, suffixes, infixes) to roots or stems to form new words. Example: The prefix "un-" added to "happy" forms the new word "unhappy".
- ✚ **Traditional Grammar:** Traditional grammar focuses on the study of language as it should be, emphasizing rules and correctness. Example: Traditional grammar dictates that a sentence must have a subject and a verb.
- ✚ **The Parts of Speech:** The parts of speech categorize words based on their function, such as nouns, verbs, adjectives, and adverbs. Example: The word "run" is a verb, while "happy" is an adjective.
- ✚ **Agreement:** Grammatical Gender: Agreement refers to the matching of words in a sentence based on gender, number, or case. Example: In French, the article "le" agrees with the masculine noun "chien" (dog).
- ✚ **Traditional Analysis:** Traditional analysis breaks down sentences into their constituent parts, identifying the subject, verb, and object. Example: In the sentence "The dog chased the ball", "The dog" is the subject, "chased" is the verb, and "the ball" is the object.
- ✚ **The Prescriptive Approach:** The prescriptive approach focuses on teaching language as it should be, emphasizing rules and correctness. Example: A prescriptive approach might dictate that "who" should be used instead of "whom" in formal writing.
- ✚ **The Descriptive Approach:** The descriptive approach studies language as it is, examining how people actually use language. Example: A descriptive approach might observe that many people use "who" and "whom" interchangeably in informal speech.
- ✚ **Structural Analysis:** Structural analysis examines the underlying structure of language, identifying patterns and relationships. Example: Structural analysis might reveal that the sentence "The dog chased the ball" follows a subject-verb-object pattern.
- ✚ **Constituent Analysis:** Constituent analysis breaks down sentences into their constituent parts, identifying the relationships between words. Example: Constituent analysis might identify the phrase "the dog" as a noun phrase functioning as the subject.

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- ✚ **Labeled and Bracketed Sentences:** Labeled and bracketed sentences use notation to identify the constituent parts of a sentence. Example: [S [NP The dog] [VP chased [NP the ball]]]
- ✚ **A Gaelic Sentence:** Gaelic sentences often use a verb-subject-object word order. Example: "Chuir mi an ball" (I threw the ball), where "Chuir" is the verb, "mi" is the subject, and "an ball" is the object.
- ✚ **SYNTAX:** Syntax studies how words are combined to form sentences and phrases. Example: The sentence "The dog chased the ball" follows a specific syntactic structure.
- ✚ **Generative Grammar:** Generative grammar proposes that language is generated by a set of rules and principles. Example: Generative grammar might posit that the sentence "The dog chased the ball" is generated by a rule combining a noun phrase with a verb phrase.
- ✚ **Properties of Generative Grammar:** Generative grammar has properties like recursion, allowing for the generation of an infinite number of sentences. Example: The recursive rule "S $\rightarrow$ NP VP" can generate an infinite number of sentences.
- ✚ **Well-Formed Syntactic Structures:** Generative grammar aims to generate well-formed syntactic structures, following the rules and principles of language. Example: The sentence "The dog chased the ball" is a well-formed syntactic structure.
- ✚ **Finite Number of Rules:** Generative grammar proposes that language can be generated by a finite number of rules. Example: A finite set of rules might generate an infinite number of sentences.
- ✚ **Recursion:** Recursion allows for the generation of an infinite number of sentences by repeating a rule or pattern. Example: The recursive rule "S $\rightarrow$ NP VP" can generate an infinite number of sentences by repeating the pattern.

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